

If you want **extra support** throughout your pregnancy, try out a few of the online **social media forums** for expectant moms—you'll be joining a wonderfully empowering and reassuring **support network** that you may want to continue with after your baby is born.

Q I'm going to be a single parent. Will I be able to manage and how can I prepare properly?

All new moms worry about being able to cope, and those concerns are often heightened if you feel you have no one to share them with. But you aren't alone. First, discuss how you feel with trusted friends and family, and with your doctor, and ask them for reassurance.

Then, even before your baby is born, start building your support network. Identify a birthing partner and share your birth plan with him or her. Talk to the people you are closest to about who can be around to help you in the first few weeks after the birth—to do some practical essentials such as the shopping or cleaning, but also to provide some companionship and to take care of the baby occasionally, so you have time to yourself (your well-being is important for your baby, too). You may want to make a list of what chores you normally do so that your "support team" knows what to do and can divide up the tasks.

Ask your doctor if she can put you in touch with other single moms-to-be, or look online for single parent groups in your area. Never be afraid to ask for help, nor to accept offers of it.

Finally, well before your due date, be sure to get organized: prepare and wash clothes and bedding for your baby, and cook yourself some nutritious meals and freeze them—stews, casseroles, and soups that you can eat using just a fork or spoon are best. Leave yourself as little as possible to do after the birth so you can spend the time fully engaged with your new baby.

Q How expensive is having a baby going to be? I'm not sure I'll be able to afford it.

You may never feel financially ready to welcome a newborn into your life, but your baby doesn't have to be a money drain if you take a realistic approach.

Although every parent wants the best for their child, it is vital not to have sky-high expectations about what your baby needs, or insist on the best. You may have a clear vision of the life you want to give your child and be anxious that you won't be able to fulfill this desire, but all your new baby really wants is to be close to you and be warm, dry, and fed. There's no need to buy every piece of baby equipment brand new. Babies quickly grow out of clothes and equipment, so it's usually easy to find good-quality secondhand items via local sales or online forums. You might also be pleasantly surprised by how

many gifts you receive—and by the money you save staying in.

It's true, however, that having a baby will impact your income if you intend to continue working and have to take child-care costs into consideration, and as your baby develops into a child and then a teenager, supporting him will become more expensive. If this is a concern, it's worthwhile to take advantage of the time you have now to make a clear financial plan. Discuss your household finances with your partner so you are both aware of the issues and responsibilities ahead and there are no misunderstandings.

You may want to discuss the idea of **setting up a joint "baby" account** and start saving for your child's future.

FINANCIAL CHECKLIST

Get your finances in order as soon as possible so that you have the right systems in place and feel in control of your money by the time your baby arrives.



HOUSEHOLD BUDGET

Look at your monthly outgoings

Pinpoint where you can save money—perhaps gym memberships and subscriptions that you rarely use, for example, or unessential purchases. If you and your partner have separate bank accounts, figure out how to share the bills and seek out the most cost-effective way to pay them. You may want to discuss the idea of setting up a "baby" account.



ENTITLEMENTS & CREDITS

Your health insurance plan

This may or may not cover the cost of your prenatal appointments during your pregnancy, and you may qualify for other benefits at work. You may also qualify for the IRS's Child Tax Credit, depending on your income.



BABY EQUIPMENT

Make a list of baby equipment

Include essential items only, and think before you buy—a bulky, unwieldy carriage may prove impractical, or a diaper disposal pail may never get used. Ask friends and family if they have items you can borrow, or buy secondhand; you may just need to buy a few new items like a changing mat and a crib mattress. If you buy new, shop around first.